

That You May Believe: John 1:1-18

We begin our new series of the year

- This series is focused on the writings and life of the apostle John
 - Showing his walk with Jesus throughout his life
 - From the gospel to Revelation

Here are the various topics...

Sermon Topics:

- Gospel of John: Word Made Flesh
- The Letters of John: The You May Know
- Revelation: Behold, He is Coming

Sermon Topics:

- Word and Witness (1-4)
- Signs of Life (5-11)
- Turning Point (12)
- The Upper Room (13-17)
- Passion and Resurrection (18-21)
- The 7 “I Am” Sayings...

But before we begin...

Here are the notes if you want to follow along

- I want to give you the notes ahead of time when I speak

That You May Believe

- I’m excited to get back to book study
- It is more exciting to preach out of one context
- John is an incredible book to study
- However, John is a unique gospel

Remember our Deep Bible Study Series...

During our midweeks we discussed the types of genres in the Bible

- Apocalyptic - Comic Book
 - Exaggerated language
- Narrative - Novel
 - Characters, meaning, symbolism, foreshadowing
- Poetic - Kanye's first album "College Dropout"
 - Exaggerated language, word pictures, very descriptive, artistic, purposeful structure
- Legal - Instructional, to the point, factual, orderly, dry reading

The Gospels have a similar feel...

The Gospels

- Matthew → Epic Historical Drama
 - The Lineage Montage: It opens with a genealogy to establish the hero's royal bloodline
- Mark → Action Blockbuster
 - Fast-paced, urgent, and high-stakes
 - Greek word "immediately" appears more than 40 times
 - There is no birth story; the movie starts right in the middle of the action at the Jordan River.
- Luke → Documentary
 - Human Interest, meticulous, capturing day in the life
 - Focuses more on the marginalize
 - More reporting than storytelling (claimed to give an orderly account)
 - You can put any documentary here but I think of the ones focused on polarizing figure
 - Capture subtle moments, show all sides of life
- John → Arthouse Philosophical Film
 - Cerebral, visual, and metaphysical
 - Doesn't stick to the traditional order of the others
 - Poetic opening, long meditative dialogues, contemplative and layered
 - Rewards rereading

So I thought matching each gospel with a movie would help you visualize...

The Gospels: Matthew

- Matthew → Epic Historical Drama
 - I thought of Gladiator

The Gospels: Mark

- Mark → Action Blockbuster
 - I thought of any Fast and Furious movie from 5 thru 10
 - Crazy pace of action

The Gospels: Luke

- Luke → Documentary
 - You can put any documentary here but I think of the ones focused on polarizing figures

The Gospels: John

- John → Arthouse Philosophical Film
 - I thought of 2001:A Space Odyssey
 - Cerebral, visual, and metaphysical
 - Doesn't stick to the traditional order of the others
 - Poetic opening, long meditative dialogues, contemplative and layered
 - Rewards rereading
 - This brings us to our key thoughts..

Layout the Main Points

Key Thoughts

- Time Will Tell
- Alien Encounter
- What Does This Mean?

Let's dive In!

1st Key Thought: Time Will Tell

Past lesson

- There was a lesson I gave a couple of months back talking about eye witnesses
- I used the example of these events to relate our personal eye witness experience
- I want to focus on one to bring the point home for the gospel John

The 9/11 Event

- It has been over two decades since this event
- It was reported heavily in the weeks, months, of the event
- But if you had to go back to share about the event, how would your story be different now?

Time gives us more depth to our experiences

- We've had time to reflect on it's significance on our country
- It had changed our country in many ways
- One that we all experience is travel
- We would tell the story with some much more context given two decades

That is where we find John when writing his gospel...

The Gospel of John

- John's gospel comes many years after the other 3 gospels
- It is written with 60 more years of Christian life lived
- It's a gospel written by the mature Christian

What Early Christians Thought:

- Origen described the Gospels as the "firstfruits" of all Scripture and the Gospel of John as the firstfruits of the Gospels
- Clement of Alexandria described it as "the spiritual Gospel"
 - Urban C. von Wahlde, "John, Gospel of," in The Lexham Bible Dictionary, ed. John D. Barry et al. (Bellingham, WA: Lexham Press, 2016).

When I think of John's Christianity when he wrote his gospel, I think of Paul's words in 1 Corinthians...

Time Will Tell

1 Corinthians 13:11-12 ERV

When I was a child, I talked like a child, I thought like a child, and I made plans like a child. When I became a man, I stopped those childish ways. [12] It is the same with us.

Now we see God as if we are looking at a reflection in a mirror. But then, in the future, we will see him right before our eyes. Now I know only a part, but at that time I will know fully, as God has known me.

Time Will Tell

- Paul simply teaches that the older he gets, God's wisdom is made more clear
- He fully knows God with time

Over time we see and experience much more that add wisdom to our lives

- Someone who has lived life for many years speak with generations of lessons behind them
- John's life experiences in his older age has shown God in a greater light

He is able to give such a mature perspective on the life of Jesus

- That is why his gospel feels more philosophical and deep

2nd Key Thought: Alien Encounter

How would you describe that experience of your life having years to think about it?

John 1:1-5,14 NIV

In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. [2] He was with God in the beginning. [3] Through him all things were made; without him nothing was made that has been made. [4] In him was life, and that life was the light of all mankind. [5] The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it. (Drop down)

[14] The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory, the glory of the one and only Son, who came from the Father, full of grace and truth.

Alien Encounter

- How John describes Jesus feels like a sci-fi intro to a movie
- Jesus is describe as this mysterious force called "Logos"
- Logos is connected to the divine God
- But it doesn't stop there
- This Logos then becomes flesh and walks among us!

John's Goal

- This is all intentional given John's audience and his years of being a Christian in the Greco-Roman World
- The idea of the Logos is deeply embedded in Greco-Roman culture
- John is addressing that idea and revealing something more special
- To feel the full weight of this passage, understanding the Romans belief in the "Logos" would help

The Logos

- Logos = the rational principle governing the universe—the underlying order behind apparent chaos
- Universal reason that structures reality—not personal, but an impersonal law or pattern
- The principle of unity in diversity—explaining how constant change could have coherent meaning

Significance:

Logos wasn't just "word" but the intelligible structure of reality itself—the reason why the cosmos is ordered rather than chaotic.

The Philosophy of Logos

- Stoic philosophy dominated the education of Greeks and Romans about the Logos
- They highly developed the idea during the writing of John's gospel

Core Stoic Concepts

- Logos as World-Soul
 - The rational, divine principle permeating all reality
 - Immanent, not transcendent—God wasn't separate from creation but infused throughout it (pantheism)
- Logos as Prime Reason
 - Contains the "seeds" (logoi spermatikoi) of all things
 - The generative principle causing things to develop according to their nature
 - Explains how acorns become oak trees, humans reach maturity—inherent rational design
- Logos in Human Beings
 - Humans possess a "spark" of the divine Logos (rationality)

- Living "according to nature" meant aligning your personal logos with the universal Logos
- Logos as Cosmic Destiny
 - Determined the fate of all things
 - Providence directing history and individual lives

Quote from Marcus Aurelius (Meditations)

"Everything is interwoven, and the web is holy; none of its parts are unconnected. They are composed harmoniously, and together they compose the world. One world, made up of all things. One divinity, present in them all. One substance and one law, the Logos common to all intelligent beings."

The Magnificence of the Gospel of John

- John deliberately chose Logos because it was philosophically loaded—his audience would immediately recognize the term
- But John radically redefines and fulfills what Logos means

The True Logos (Common Ground)

- ✓ Logos is the rational principle behind creation (v. 3)
- ✓ Logos is divine in nature (v. 1)
- ✓ Logos provides light/illumination to humanity (v. 4-5)
- Logos is pre-existent, eternal (v. 1-2)

The True Logos (What's New)

- Logos is Personal and Knowable
- Logos is Distinct Yet Equal to God
- Logos Became Flesh

This blew the minds of John's audience

- It would be like all theories of physics about the known universe taking shape a person and entering our existence (Theory of Everything)

And the goal of this Logos was to bring Light into the world

- Both physically and spiritually
- Fulfilling prophecy by Isaiah

Isaiah 9:1-7 NIV

Nevertheless, there will be no more gloom for those who were in distress. In the past he humbled the land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali, but in the future he will honor Galilee of the nations, by the Way of the Sea, beyond the Jordan— [2] The people walking in darkness have seen a great light; on those living in the land of deep darkness a light has dawned. [3] You have enlarged the nation and increased their joy; they rejoice before you as people rejoice at the harvest, as warriors rejoice when dividing the plunder. [4] For as in the day of Midian's defeat, you have shattered the yoke that burdens them, the bar across their shoulders, the rod of their oppressor. [5] Every warrior's boot used in battle and every garment rolled in blood will be destined for burning, will be fuel for the fire. [6] For to us a child is born, to us a son is given, and the government will be on his shoulders. And he will be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace. [7] Of the greatness of his government and peace there will be no end. He will reign on David's throne and over his kingdom, establishing and upholding it with justice and righteousness from that time on and forever. The zeal of the LORD Almighty will accomplish this.

He is now here entering human history!

- And the logos says it himself in the gospel of John

John 12:46 NIV

I have come into the world as a light, so that no one who believes in me should stay in darkness.

Is this not incredible!

- John has had all this time to think about the impact Jesus has had on his life but for all humankind
- He has had years of seeing great miracles and lives changed
- And he comes away with the answer to the force holding the whole universe together, even life itself was Jesus

Brings us to our last point...

Last Key Thought: What Does This Mean?

- How did John contextualize this moment?
- Let's go back to John chapter 1 starting in verse 6

What Does This Mean?

John 1:6-9 NIV

There was a man sent from God whose name was John. [7] He came as a witness to testify concerning that light, so that through him all might believe. [8] He himself was not the light; he came only as a witness to the light. [9] The true light that gives light to everyone was coming into the world.

What was John's conclusion

Conclusion

We are witnesses to share about this Logos of light...

- To dedicate our lives preaching the light of Christ
- Preaching light through our example
- Preaching light through our words
- Preaching light through our love

Questions to Consider

Does you see Jesus as the light of your life?

How are you preaching his light to the world around you?

Let 2026 be a year of sharing the Light of the gospel message

- Telling everyone about God's word
- His Logos

The answer to the universe was and is here and he wants to bring light to your life

Thank you